ISSUE 8

GALLIONS grapevine

April 2002

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION



Pictured above, new road sweeper.

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A New Broom

Team Gallions ENVIRONMENTAL SERVICES

Team Gallions is now settling into the new cleaning and grounds maintenance routines. The service now operates every day of the week, although some tasks, such as grass cutting, are only done on weekdays so that it does not affect your weekends!

We are also carrying out a series of experiments to see which improvements to our service work best and best meet your priorities.

One of these is the early morning cleaning of lifts. We tried this in four tower blocks during March. The cleaning took place between 6am and 8am on Saturday and Sunday mornings and was designed to ensure that the lifts were hygienic and clean after the previous night. We are now looking at the results of this experiment and, if successful, we shall incorporate this into regular routine work.

Team Gallions will be formally launched in May at Birchmere Park. The launch has been designed with local schools with school children in mind. They will be able to join a new club called the Environment Rangers and work with Gallions to improve the cleanliness and appearance of Thamesmead so that it really can be a place to be proud of.

We are also working with residents to specify the service in some detail so that we can circulate leaflets describing the service during May and June 2002.

Also over the next month we are recruiting another 27 people into Team Gallions so that we improve our service still further. This increase in staff and the purchase of a wide range of new equipment is a substantial investment from Gallions. We will now be working to achieve a sense of partnership with residents, as it is only by working together that Thamesmead will really look better.

However in the meantime we have had feedback from some of our residents who are delighted with the results up to now. This includes a resident from West Thamesmead who said: "It is heartening and refreshing to find that there are still people about who soldier on, often in difficult and unpleasant conditions, to help the community. This was apparent recently when some members of Team Gallions swiftly and sympathetically responded to my call for help in protecting the waterbirds and their eggs on Gallions Lake from possible vandalism".

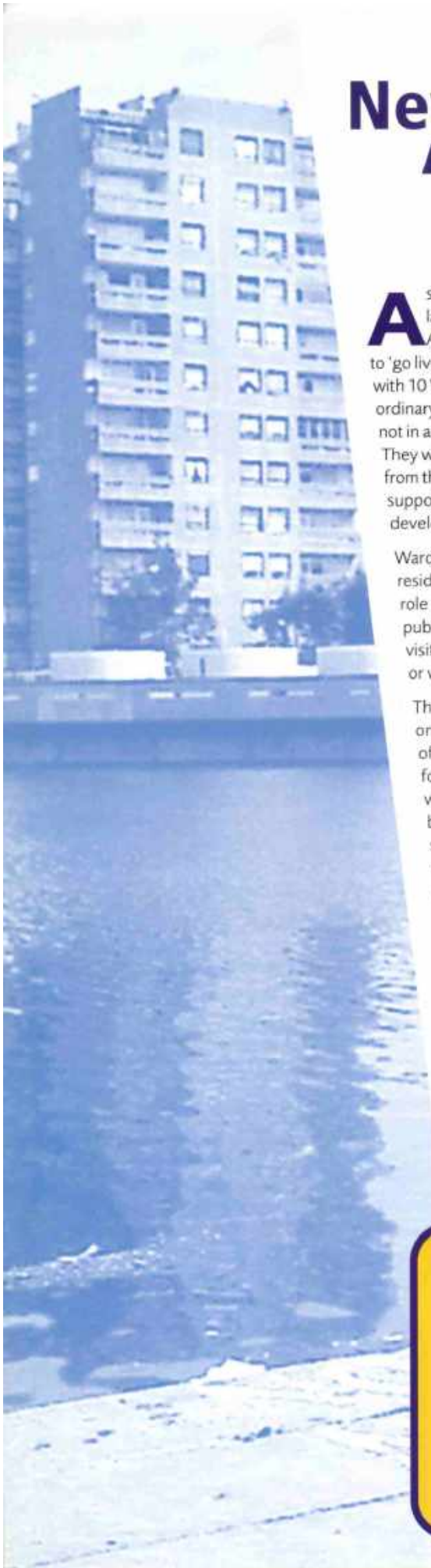
FREE *fridge magnet enclosed*

See article on page 5.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

One click to explore our new interactive website

www.gallionsha.co.uk



New community "eyes & ears"

As you may have already heard, there will be a Neighbourhood Wardens pilot project launch in summer 2002. This pilot project is being funded by Gallions Housing Association, Greenwich Council, SRB4 and the Government. Our project is scheduled to 'go live' in June/July 2002 and will provide Thamesmead Moorings and Eynsham Wards with 10 Wardens. We are currently recruiting for these posts which will be made up of 8 ordinary patrolling Wardens, a Supervisory Warden and a Wardens Project Manager. They are not in any way connected with the police and will only have the powers of an ordinary citizen. They will, however, be fully trained to deal with minor situations and will also take reports from the community about local environmental problems and nuisance. The scheme is fully supported by the police and, along with other relevant services, they are helping us to develop a project that most suits the area.

Wardens will provide a valuable community resource, acting as the 'eyes and ears' of local residents, providing a link with environmental, housing and other public services. Their role will include following up complaints, providing feedback and encouraging greater public involvement in tackling issues that affect residents. Wardens will also make regular visits to elderly and vulnerable residents to ensure that they feel less isolated, intimidated or worried about crime.

The main part of their day to day activities will be to provide a visible, patrolling presence on the streets. In order to help the community to identify them, they will wear a uniform of royal blue fleeces, sweatshirts, polo shirts and high visibility jackets. We have set up a focus group that includes residents from Thamesmead Moorings and Eynsham, which will be actively involved in helping to identify priorities for the Wardens when they begin their operational duties. They have already been involved in deciding on issues such as uniform colours and logos, but will also be instrumental in deciding the working arrangements for the Wardens (subject to Health and Safety/Employment contract constraints). It is hoped that they will cover 5 days out of 7 and will work between the hours of 10am to 10pm in various shifts. It is unlikely that we will be able to cover 10am to 10 pm every day, but hours will be determined to take account of what is happening in the area and what coverage is needed. We have to be realistic about what we can achieve with the resources available but with your help, we will be able to maximise their coverage and effectiveness.

Now that Gallions have a dedicated Community Safety Team, it will be possible to maintain a constant review of crime prevention and community safety needs across the whole of Thamesmead. The Wardens project is a significant step forward and we are now working closely with the London Borough of Bexley with a view to expanding the scheme to cover the remainder of Thamesmead, if we can get the resources needed to pay for it.

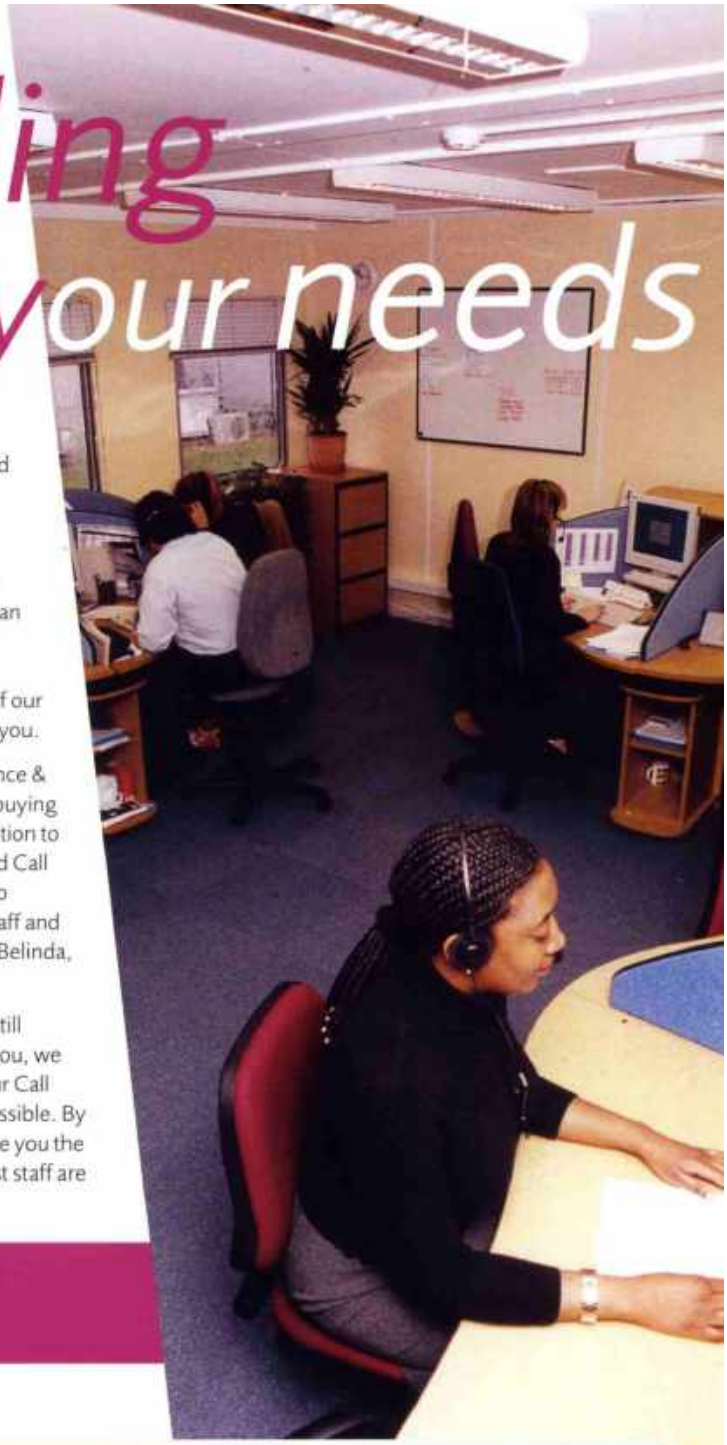
A new voice for leaseholders

Gallions Housing Association is establishing a Leasehold Forum as part of the Association's resident participation strategy. The aim of this group will be to look at the issues for leaseholders and to seek views on the services and ways of improving them. The group members will lead the role of the group and you will determine the level of your involvement.

If you would like to be part of this group, please contact Zena Lee on 020 8320 3403 or Jill McNiven on 020 8320 3417.

See back page for your list of contacts

Responding to your needs



Gallions' commitment to its customers is shining through with the on-going development of our Customer Response Centre.

Previously providing a repairs-only service, the newly expanded Customer Response Centre has become the hub of the association and now handles all of our telephone calls. In addition to requests for repairs the Customer Response Centre can now deal with all tenancy matters by phone and what's more its free! Just dial 0800 838481 and you pay nothing at all. If you have more than one tenancy-related enquiry then we will also be able to help you without having to transfer you, one call is all you need to make. If the Customer Response Centre can't help then we will arrange for one of our specialist members of staff to call you or arrange an appointment for you.

Our team of Call Advisers now deals with all general enquires, nuisance & harassment problems, rent and service charge queries, re-housing, buying your property and garage enquiries to name just a few. This is in addition to continuing to offer a first class repairs service. We have highly trained Call Advisers who are there to help you and, as part of our commitment to develop the best possible services, we have invested in more new staff and technology. Ross, Kelly, Cara and Jeannette have all joined Michael, Belinda, Sarah and Georgina to form the team.

We're looking for more people so that we can improve our services still further. To help our team in the Customer Response Centre to help you, we have started to implement new computer systems that will enable our Call Advisers to provide the most complete telephone-based services possible. By developing our telephone-based services in this way we not only give you the best value possible but we are also making sure that our key specialist staff are freed up to spend more time working directly within the community.

Call us on 0800 83 84 81 and experience the difference.

Thamesmead – a diverse community

As part of its efforts at involving the Thamesmead community in decision-making and meeting their needs, Gallions has set up a Steering Group to devise a strategy for black and minority ethnic people in Thamesmead. Tokky Ademoyero, a tenant Board member, chairs the group.

The strategy will, among other things:

- Identify community groups and individuals from within those groups
- Consult with them on matters that affect them
- Meet their needs
- Consider the implications for the black and minority ethnic community in all decision making processes.

This effort will help shape the future of Thamesmead and is part of a nation-wide approach towards a healthier community for present and future families. Gallions invites you to join us in shaping this future.

If you are interested in our work and would like to help please contact the Steering Group's chair, Tokky Ademoyero on tademoyero@gallionsha.co.uk.

Alternatively, you can write to Tokky
c/o Sue Chalkley,
Gallions Housing Association,
Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Confused by the maze of benefits?



Derek Stainsby Gallions Welfare Benefits Officer or WBO for short has now taken up his post.

Derek can help you with any housing benefit problems and can also advise on a range of benefits including working families tax credit, income support/job seekers allowance, incapacity and disability benefits.

He can help prepare your case for tribunals and may be able to represent you at the hearing should it be necessary.

Derek has many years of experience of benefits. He has been a claimant himself in the past and so he understands how difficult the process can sometimes be. He has also worked for local authorities processing housing benefit claims for over 10 years.

Derek's aim at all times will be to ensure that you get all the money that you are entitled to.

You can make a confidential appointment by calling 020 8320 3485 or call the Gallions freephone number 0800 83 84 81 and ask for ext 211.

Customer Response Centre Prize Winners

Your feedback is of so much importance to us that since December 2001 the Customer Services Department have been offering those tenants who complete and return their 'Customer Satisfaction' questionnaires, the opportunity to enter into a prize draw.

For a chance to become one of our lucky monthly winners just complete the 'Customer Satisfaction' questionnaire on the Repair Acknowledgement letter that you receive when you report a repair, telling us what you thought of the repair service.

Mrs Downey of Leonard Robbins Path was our December winner, Mrs Chidavaenzi of Beveridge Court won in February and Mr and Mrs Ahern from Moorings were our Easter winners.

Pictured right, Mrs Chidavaenzi.



GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

www.gallionsha.co.uk

New improved web

We re-launched our web site on 26th March 2002 in the Tenants Resource Centre. Staff and local residents were invited to the launch to join us for a coffee and to find out how the new interactive website worked.

The day was enjoyed by all, with residents joining in the fun. We had an Easter Egg hunt, competitions and prize draws for those who attended.

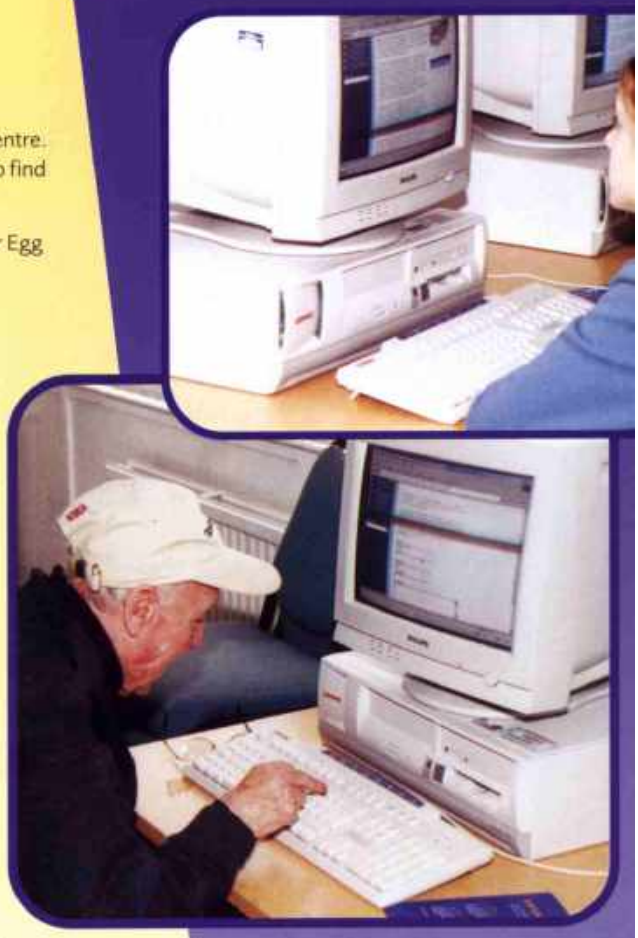
Since the launch we have had lots of feedback from residents including:

"excellent website, extremely informative, very impressive."

"I have browsed through your web site and enjoyed it, particularly the eco-park development."

"I think that the new website is very interesting. The text could be a little bigger for those who have difficulty reading. Overall the aim to help the people of Thamesmead has been achieved."

We hope the website will provide an extra communication platform for our customers and residents to get involved. If you have any comments or content you would like to add or discuss please contact Kaye Sene on 0208 320 3462.



Mr Collins proved that it is never too late to learn by getting to grips with our website.

Fond Farewell

On Friday 12th April Gallions said "Goodbye" to a much-loved member of staff, Mary Pittman, who retired from the Association after working as an elderly persons Warden for over 23 years.

Apart from her work as a Warden, Mary is a well-loved figure in the community. She still spends many hours organising events for the elderly in Thamesmead. These included trips to the seaside and Bingo. She is regularly found helping out at the Pop in Parlour at lunchtimes.

Billy is usually at her side during these organised events and is a great Bingo caller. The two of them are always up for a laugh, and I expect many of you will remember when they and their team entertained you with antics like Mary dressing up as one of the Abba girls and Billy as Tom Jones.

Good luck Mary, we will all miss you.



GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Tavy Bridge *Regeneration Project*

Trees for Thamesmead – Urban forest created in Thamesmead

An incredible seven thousand new, young trees have been planted in Thamesmead since January this year. This is part of the Trees for Thamesmead project being carried out by Groundwork for the National Urban Forestry Unit. The trees were planted with the help of over 1200 volunteers including children from 6 schools and will make an instant impact on the lives of many local residents.

Children from Northwood School, Thamesmead, together with John Fahy Chair of Gallions took up their spades on Tuesday 9th March to plant nearly 300 trees within the school grounds. This mini wood will provide shade, reduce noise and create an exciting environment to explore and learn from.

Now these trees are in the ground the project will be searching for new sites in Thamesmead and Abbey Wood to plant next winter. Local residents and businesses are being asked to contact the Urban Forestry Officer for the Green Gateway, Pherenice Worsey-Buck, on 01708 641 880 if they wish to become involved in this scheme.



From left to right: Danielle Walker, Joe Perkins, John Fahy, Miss McNulty, Robyn Beaham.

Tavy Bridge *Update*

Consultation:

We have begun the consultation process for the regeneration proposals on Tavy Bridge. Over the last few months, we have been have been working with local residents and stakeholders to develop the regeneration proposals and ideas.

Since the Tavy Bridge survey was carried out last summer, a Focus Group consisting of local people has been established. This group has met regularly, identified some immediate proposals, discussed design issues and will now plan further consultation events for the summer months.

Good news:

Gallions and the Tavy Bridge Focus Group have been successful in attracting £114,750 in SRB Funding from the Abbeywood and Thamesmead SRB programme for a series of immediate initiatives to improve community safety in the area. Improvements will now be made to the lighting, security and the environment in and around Tavy Bridge.

What happens now?

A huge amount of project planning work needs to be done. Physical solutions alone will not solve everything, so Community Renewal staff will be working with local people and agencies to implement community-led projects alongside the physical works. We also need to look at how the project will be managed and make sure that the appropriate funding is in place. We will continue to talk to local stakeholders to make sure that the proposals work for everyone in Tavy Bridge.

The process has now started but it is by no means over and consultation will be ongoing throughout the life of the project. Gallions is committed to the regeneration of Tavy Bridge and is keen to hear from anyone who would like further information, or who has ideas about improvements to the area.

Please contact Claire Irvine, Community Renewal Manager on 020 8320 3494 or cirvine@gallionsha.co.uk. There is also information on our website www.gallionsha.co.uk

See back page for your list of contacts

Get partying

Queen's Golden Jubilee

1 – 4 June 2002

The Gallions Street Parties Committee has allocated grants to ten successful local community groups to hold parties over the Jubilee weekend. As a result Thamesmead will be holding more parties than any other area of London to celebrate the Queens Golden Jubilee. No party poopers in Thamesmead!



Pictured above, John Fahy, Chair presenting a cheque to Annette, Leah, Pat and Carol from the Sanderling Court Social Club.

Affordable home ownership opportunities in Erith

Tower Homes are ready to invite people to view new homes along the waterfront and Manor Road in Erith. The homes will be sold on a part buy, part rent basis (shared ownership) and are part of Bexley Council's regeneration initiative.

So what is shared ownership? Put simply, it is one solution for a growing number of people who want to own a home of their own, but who are unable to buy outright. You can buy an initial share in a home and pay a low rent on the remainder, with the option to buy more shared should your financial circumstances change.

Tower Homes is selling four 1 bedroom starter houses at Britannia Close, Manor Road and a mix of 2 bedroom apartments and 3 bedroom houses at Wharfside Close through this scheme. Prices start from £40,500 for a 45% share in a one bedroom home.

Priority will be given to housing association tenants living in the borough of Bexley.

For more information on these homes and shared ownership call us free on 0800 056 3601 or email us at www.towerhomes.org.uk.

Board Decisions from 21st March 2002

- **Housing Corporation Performance Standing B3 – Propriety and Probity**
  The Board endorsed the contents of a report, committing to ensure that Board members and staff demonstrate full compliance with Housing Corporation Performance Standard B3 at all times.
- **Procurement and Tendering Procedures**
  The Board approved new procedures for procurement and tendering which strengthen and consolidate the existing polices and procedures and provide a consistent approached based on estimated tender values. The procedures were revised taking account of best practice operated in other public institutions within and outside the social housing sector.
- **SRB4/Community Safety**
  The Association's bid for SRB4 funds has been successful and we have received funding towards three projects:
  - **Neighbourhood Wardens (details on page 2)**
  - **Regeneration of Tavy Bridge – Phase One – Environmental and Security Works (details on page 6)**
  - **Thamesmead Police Motorcycle Project.**

Board Meetings

Gallions Housing Association's Board of Management meets on a regular basis. The meetings are open to all residents.

In order to accommodate any residents who wish to attend, you would need to contact Averyl Richards at our offices, (address below) prior to any meeting to make arrangements.

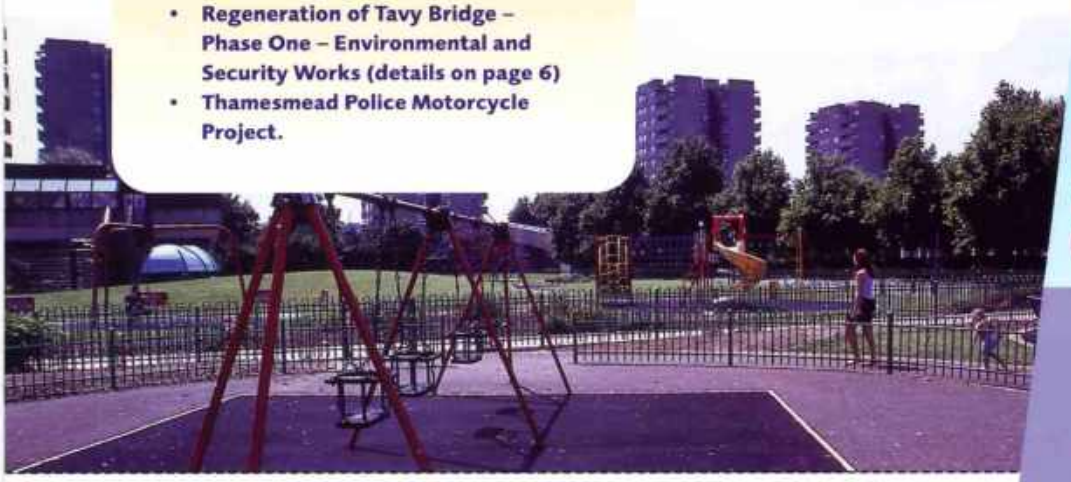
The dates of the next meetings are:

13 June 2002

19 September 2002

12 December 2002

All meetings are held at Gallions Housing Association offices, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH at 6.30pm.



ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phong bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Caroline Wilson (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

FEEDBACK

What do you think of "Gallions Grapevine"? Have you any comments on our service – good or bad? What is your view of living in Thamesmead?

Let us know by writing to **FEEDBACK, Gallions Grapevine, c/o Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.**

Feedback from a reader (details withheld):

"I heard so many bad things about Thamesmead, but now I live here I wouldn't want to live anywhere else. I love it."

Contacts

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London SE2 9XH

Customer Response Centre

Freephone

0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls. The old switchboard number will be dissolved in the coming months.

Comfort 2000 Heating

020 8320 3422

Interserve

0800 389 0154